

# Session 16: The One Becomes Two

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## Key Takeaways

- The woman is created not as an inferior assistant but as the agent of God's deliverance.
- The picture of God taking one of the human's sides shows that the woman is the equal, corresponding other without whom the ideal of Genesis 1 cannot be fully realized.

## Key Words from Genesis 2:18-25

Genesis 2:18-25 introduces some key vocabulary regarding gender that has created a range of interpretations throughout history. It's important to explore the meaning of several of these Hebrew words in their original context.

## Word Study: Helper — 'Ezer (עֵזֶר)

The phrase *'ezer kenegdo* (כְּנֶגְדּוֹ עֵזֶר) has been translated differently in the history of the English versions: "help meet" (KJV), "helper suitable" (NIV, NAS), "helper fit" (NRSV), "a helper to bear him company" (Tyndale).

## Translation Comparisons of Genesis 2:18

### Genesis 2:18 NIV

The LORD God said, "It is not good for the man to be alone. I will make a helper suitable for him."

### Genesis 2:18 ESV

Then the LORD God said, "It is not good for the man to be alone. I will make a helper fit for him."

### Genesis 2:18 NASB

Then the LORD God said, "It is not good for the man to be alone. I will make a helper suitable for him."

### Genesis 2:18 NRSV

Then the LORD God said, "It is not good that the man should be alone. I will make him a helper as his partner."

### Genesis 2:18 NLT

The LORD God said, "It is not good for the man to be alone. I will make a helper who is just right for him."

### Genesis 2:18 KJV

And the LORD God said, “It is not good that the man should be alone; I will make him an help meet for him.”

## Variety in Early Interpretations

The earliest translations show a variety of interpretations.

- Old Greek: “a help according to him” (βοηθὸν κατ’ αὐτόν)
- Targum Neofiti: “a partner who comes as one with him” = “a partner similar to him” (זוג בד נפק ביה)
- Targum Pseudo-Jonathan and Onkelos: “a support according to him” (סמך בקבליה)
- Latin Vulgate: “a helper similar to him” (adiutorium similem sui)

The word help (עֵזֶר) does not mean “assistant” or “helper.” Rather, it describes someone who plays the role of the indispensable other without whom the desired good cannot happen. The noun is masculine in grammatical gender, which means the word is a kind of title or role descriptor, not an adjective (e.g., female assistant).

## Concordance Search of the Word “Help-Counterpart”

The noun “help” occurs 21 times in the Hebrew Bible. Outside of Genesis 2, it is only used to describe Yahweh as a deliverer of his people, or of useless humans who provide “no help” compared to Yahweh.

### Exodus 18:4 NIV\*

And the other was named Eli‘ezer, for he said, “My father’s God was my ‘ezer; he saved me from the sword of Pharaoh.”

\*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

### Deuteronomy 33:7 NIV\*

And this he said about Judah: “Hear, LORD, the cry of Judah; bring him to his people. With his own hands he defends his cause. Oh, be his ‘ezer against his foes!”

\*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

### Deuteronomy 33:26-27 NIV\*

<sup>26</sup> There is no one like the God of Jeshurun, who rides across the heavens as your ‘ezer and on the clouds in his majesty. <sup>27</sup> The eternal God is your refuge, and underneath are the everlasting arms. He will drive out your enemies before you, saying, “Destroy them!”

\*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

### Deuteronomy 33:29 NIV\*

Blessed are you, Israel! Who is like you, a people saved by the LORD? He is your shield and ‘ezer and your glorious sword. Your enemies will cower before you, and you will tread on their heights.

\*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

### Hosea 13:9 NIV\*

You are destroyed, Israel, because you are against me, against your ‘ezer.

\*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

### **Psalms 20:1-2 NIV\***

<sup>1</sup> May the LORD answer you when you are in distress; may the name of the God of Jacob protect you. <sup>2</sup> May he send you **‘ezer** from the sanctuary and grant you support from Zion.

\*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

### **Psalms 33:18-20 NIV\***

<sup>18</sup> But the eyes of the LORD are on those who fear him,  
on those whose hope is in his unfailing love,

<sup>19</sup> to deliver them from death  
and keep them alive in famine.

<sup>20</sup> We wait in hope for the LORD;  
he is our **‘ezer** and our shield.

\*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

### **Psalms 121:1-2 NIV\***

<sup>1</sup> I lift up my eyes to the mountains—where does my **‘ezer** come from? <sup>2</sup> My **‘ezer** comes from the LORD, the maker of Heaven and Earth.

\*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

### **Psalms 146:5-6 NIV\***

<sup>5</sup> Blessed are those whose **‘ezer** is the God of Jacob,  
whose hope is in the LORD their God.

<sup>6</sup> He is the maker of Heaven and Earth, the sea, and everything in them—  
he remains faithful forever.

\*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

### **Isaiah 30:3-5 NIV\***

<sup>3</sup> But Pharaoh’s protection will be to your shame,  
Egypt’s shade will bring you disgrace.

<sup>4</sup> Though they have officials in Zoan  
and their envoys have arrived in Hanes,

<sup>5</sup> everyone will be put to shame because of a people useless to them,  
who bring neither **‘ezer** nor advantage, but only shame and disgrace.

\*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

### **Ezekiel 12:13-14 NIV\***

<sup>13</sup> ... I will bring [Zedekiah] to Babylonia, the land of the Chaldeans, but he will not see it, and there he will die. <sup>14</sup> I will scatter to the winds all those around him—his staff and all his **‘ezer**—and I will pursue them with drawn sword.

\*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

The word 'ezer is often used to describe military backup, though in context, it always portrays such military power as powerless compared to Yahweh's 'ezer.

## Defining “Help”

The word help (עֵזֶר) does not mean “assistant” or “helper.” Rather, it describes someone who plays the role of the indispensable other without whom the desired good cannot happen.

## Word Study: Corresponding to Him — *Kenegdo* (כִּנְגְדּוֹ)

Let's look at the other half of the phrase in Genesis 2:18: “helper corresponding to him.” This is a compound word “ke” (כ) “like, as, according to” + “neged” (כִּנְגַד) “in front of, opposite.” The word “neged” means, basically, “in front of, before.”

### Exodus 19:2 NIV\*

... and Israel camped there in the desert **in front of** (*neged*) the mountain.

\*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

### Exodus 34:10 NIV\*

**Before** (*neged*) all your people, I will do wonders never before done in any nation in all the world.

\*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Genesis 2:18 and 20 are the only occurrences of this preposition with *neged*, though the preposition's meaning of “like, as” indicates similarity. Given the spatial imagery of “in front of,” the meaning seems to be “similar to what would face him.” We might use a metaphor of mirroring to get the core idea.

“The last part of v. 18 reads literally, ‘I will make him for him a helper as in front of him (or according to what is in front of him).’ This last phrase, ‘as in front of him (or according to what is in front of him)’ (*keneḡdô*), occurs only here and in v. 20. It suggests that what God creates for Adam will correspond to him. Thus the new creation will be neither a superior nor an inferior, but an equal. The creation of this helper will form one-half of a polarity, and will be to man as the south pole is to the north pole.”

Hamilton, Victor P. (1990). [\*The Book of Genesis, Chapters 1-17\*](#). Eerdmans.

## Defining “Helper Corresponding to Him”

If we combine our study of these two words, 'ezer and *neged*, we produce the following paraphrase of Genesis 2:18.

“It is not good for the human to be solitary. I will make one who can deliver him from his inability to fulfill the divine commission alone, one who mirrors him.”

"This new creation which man needs is called a helper ('ezer), which is masculine in gender, though here it is a term for woman. Any suggestion that this particular word denotes one who has only an associate or subordinate status to a senior member is refuted by the fact that most frequently this same word describes Yahweh's relationship to Israel. He is Israel's help(er) because he is the stronger one (see, e.g., Exod. 18:4; Deut. 33:7, 26, 29; Ps. 33:20; 115:9-11; 124:8; 146:5; etc.) ... The word is used less frequently for human helpers, and even here, the helper is one appealed to because of superior military strength (Isa. 30:5) or superior size (Ps. 121:1). The verb behind 'ezer is 'azar, which means ... 'save from danger,' 'deliver from death.' The woman in Gen. 2 delivers or saves man from his solitude."

Hamilton, Victor P. (1990). [\*The Book of Genesis, Chapters 1-17\*](#). Eerdmans.

## Word Study: Deep Sleep — *Tardemah* (תרדמה)

There is another Hebrew word we'll need to explore in order to understand the full meaning of this story: "*tardemah*" or "deep sleep." This uncommon word appears only a handful of times in the Bible, and it is not the normal word for "sleep" (*yashan* / ישן). Take a look at where it occurs in the Genesis 2 narrative.

### Genesis 2:21-22 Instructor's Translation

<sup>21</sup> and Yahweh caused to fall a **deep sleep** on the human and he slept  
and he took one from his sides  
and he closed the flesh of its place

<sup>22</sup> and Yahweh built the side which he took from the human into woman

## Connections with Genesis 15

Note the commonalities between Genesis 2:18-25 and God's covenant with Abraham in Genesis 15.

### Genesis 15:2-21 NASB\*

<sup>2</sup> Abram said, "O Lord God, what will you give me, since I am childless, and the heir of my house is **Eliezer** of Damascus?" <sup>3</sup> And Abram said, "Since you have given no **offspring** to me, one born in my house is my heir. <sup>4</sup> Then behold, the word of the LORD came to him, saying, "This man will not be your heir; but one who will come forth **from your own body**, he shall be your heir." <sup>5</sup> And he took him outside and said, "Now look toward the heavens, and count the stars, if you are able to count them." And he said to him, "So shall your descendants be." <sup>6</sup> Then he believed in the LORD; and he reckoned it to him as righteousness. <sup>7</sup> And he said to him, "I am the LORD who brought you out of Ur of the Chaldeans, to give you this land to possess it." <sup>8</sup> He said, "O Lord God, how may I know that I will possess it?" <sup>9</sup> So he said to him, "Bring me a three year old heifer, and a three year old female goat, and a three year old ram, and a turtledove, and a young pigeon." <sup>10</sup> Then he brought all these to him and cut them in two, and laid each half opposite the other; but he did not cut the birds. <sup>11</sup> The birds of prey came down upon the carcasses, and Abram drove them away. <sup>12</sup> Now when the sun was going down, a **deep sleep** fell upon Abram; and behold, terror and great darkness fell upon him. <sup>13</sup> God said to Abram, "Know for certain that your descendants will be strangers in a land that is not theirs, where they will be enslaved and oppressed four hundred years. <sup>14</sup> But I will also judge the nation

whom they will serve, and afterward they will come out with many possessions.<sup>15</sup> As for you, you shall go to your fathers in peace; you will be buried at a good old age.<sup>16</sup> Then in the fourth generation they will return here, for the iniquity of the Amorite is not yet complete.”<sup>17</sup> It came about when the sun had set, that it was very dark, and behold, there appeared **a smoking oven and a flaming torch which passed between these pieces**.<sup>18</sup> On that day the LORD made a **covenant** with Abram, saying, “To your descendants I have given this land, from the river of Egypt as far as the great river, the river Euphrates: <sup>19</sup> the Kenite and the Kenizzite and the Kadmonite<sup>20</sup> and the Hittite and the Perizzite and the Rephaim<sup>21</sup> and the Amorite and the Canaanite and the Girgashite and the Jebusite.”

\*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

HELP = EZER = עֶזֶר  
 SEED = ZERA' = זֶרַע

*Help and Seed Wordplay.* Illustration created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Adam to Noah (2020).

## Tardemah Throughout the Bible

This uncommon word appears only a handful of times in the Bible, and it is not the normal word for “sleep” (*yashan* / יָשָׁן). There is both a noun, “deep sleep,” and a verb, “to fall into a deep sleep” (*radam*). Both refer to a comatose state of helplessness and vulnerability that is attributed to God’s power. Adam’s tardemah begins an important design pattern in the Hebrew Bible connected to this word. God causes tardemah to fall upon either his partners to demonstrate their inability to help themselves and bring about God’s plan and blessing, or his enemies so that they are reduced to helplessness.

## God Causes a Deep Sleep to Fall on His Partners

- Adam in Genesis 2:21: God prevents Adam from providing his own “help.”
- Abraham in Genesis 15:12: God prevents Abram from walking down the aisle of animal pieces.
- Daniel in Daniel 8:18 and 10:9: Daniel goes into a deep sleep as he experiences his visions of the coming of God’s Kingdom.

### God Causes a Deep Sleep to Fall on His Enemies

- Sisera in Judges 4:21: He is in a deep sleep in Jael’s tent when she kills him.
- Saul and his soldiers in 1 Samuel 26:12: Saul is prevented from waking and capturing David.
- Judah’s leaders in Isaiah 29:10: God cuts off all communication through prophets to Judah’s leaders.
- Jonah in Jonah 1:5-6: Jonah runs from God and tries to escape to his self-made Eden.
- Psalms 76:6: God rebukes enemy warriors and reduces them to deep sleep.

## Word Study: Rib — *Tsela'* (צלע)

There is one last word to explore in this session: “*tsela'*,” or “rib” as we see it translated in Genesis 2:21. Does it really mean “rib”?

### Genesis 2:21 NIV

So the LORD God caused the man to fall into a deep sleep; and while he was sleeping, he took one of the man’s **ribs** and then closed up the place with flesh.

### Genesis 2:21 ESV

So the LORD God caused a deep sleep to fall upon the man, and while he slept took one of his **ribs** and closed up its place with flesh.

### Genesis 2:21 NASB

So the LORD God caused a deep sleep to fall upon the man, and he slept; then he took one of his **ribs** and closed up the flesh at that place.

### Genesis 2:21 NRSV

So the LORD God caused a deep sleep to fall upon the man, and he slept; then he took one of his **ribs** and closed up its place with flesh.

### Genesis 2:21 NLT

So the LORD God caused a deep sleep to fall upon the man, and while he slept took one of his **ribs** and closed up its place with flesh.

## Concordance Search of *Tsela'* (צלע)

There are 40 occurrences of the word *tsela'* (צלע) in the Hebrew Bible. The only time it is translated into anatomical terms is in Genesis 2:21. The rest of the occurrences are in architectural terms.

### Exodus 25:12 NASB



You shall cast four gold rings for it and fasten them on its four feet, and two rings shall be on one **side** of it and two rings on the **other side** of it.

**Exodus 25:14 NASB**

You shall put the poles into the rings on the **sides** of the ark, to carry the ark with them.

**Exodus 26:20 NASB**

... and for the second **side** of the tabernacle, on the north side, twenty boards ...

**Exodus 26:26 NASB**

Also make crossbars of acacia wood, five for the frames on one **side** of the tabernacle ...

**Exodus 26:35 NASB**

You shall set the table outside the veil, and the lampstand opposite the table on the **side** of the tabernacle toward the south; and you shall put the table on the north **side**.

**2 Samuel 16:13 NASB**

So David and his men went on the way; and Shimei went along on the **hillside** parallel with him and as he went he cursed and cast stones and threw dust at him.

**1 Kings 6:5 NASB**

Against the wall of the house he built stories encompassing the walls of the house around both the nave and the inner sanctuary; thus he made **side** chambers all around.

The word *tsela'* does not mean "rib;" it means "side." This term is used elsewhere in the Hebrew Bible to describe the construction of the tabernacle or temple, which is the sacred space God provides to meet with his people and deliver them.

"The word [*tsela'*] is used about forty times in the Hebrew Bible but is not an anatomical term in any other passage. Outside of Genesis 2, with the exception of 2 Samuel 16:13 (referring to the other side of the hill), the word is only used architecturally in the tabernacle/temple passages (Exod. 25-38; 1 Kgs. 6-7; Ezek. 41). It can refer to planks or beams in these passages, but more often it refers to one side or the other, typically when there are two sides (rings along two sides of the ark; rooms on two sides of the temple, the north or south side; etc.). On the basis of Adam's statement, combined with these data on usage, we would have to conclude that God took one of Adam's sides—likely meaning he cut Adam in half and from one side built the woman."

Walton, John H. (2015). [\*The Lost World of Adam and Eve: Genesis 2-3 and the Human Origins Debate\*](#). IVP Academic: An Imprint of InterVarsity Press.

"[T]he text says that God took one of the *šēlā'* of man. Almost without exception this word has been translated as 'rib' (hence even today the many puns on 'Adam's rib' and 'women's lib'). A better translation of *šēlā'* is side. The word designates a side or the shell of the ark of the covenant (Exod. 25:12, 14; 37:3, 5), the side of a building (Exod. 26:20; 36:25) or even a whole room ('side chamber, arcade, cell,' Ezek. 41:5-8), or a ridge or terrace on a hill (2 Sam. 16:13). Gen. 2:21 is the only place in the OT where the modern versions



render this word as 'rib' ... The passage states that woman was created from an undesignated part of man's body rather than from one of his organs or from a portion of bony tissue."

Hamilton, Victor P. (1990). [\*The Book of Genesis, Chapters 1-17\*](#). Eerdmans.

## God "Builds" the "Side" Into a Woman

Interpreters have long noticed the architectural vocabulary of Genesis 2:21-22.

### Genesis 2:21-22 NASB\*

<sup>21</sup> And [God] took one from [the human's] **side**, and he **closed** flesh in its place, <sup>22</sup> and he **built** the **side** ... into a woman.

\*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

All of these terms are used elsewhere in the Hebrew Bible to describe the construction of a building—and not just any building! This same vocabulary occurs in the narratives where God provides a sacred space where he will meet with his people and deliver them.

- The ark of Noah (see [Gen. 6:14-22](#); [7:15-16](#))
- The tabernacle and the ark of the covenant (see [Exod. 25:10-22](#))
- The temple (see [1 Kgs. 6:1-38](#))
- The new temple and the new Jerusalem, aka "Lady Zion" ([Isa. 54](#) and [60](#))

The building of the woman deliverer begins a design pattern that is fundamental to the biblical narrative: God's provision of a blessing, deliverance, or sacred gift that is meant to bring the protagonist into closer union with God. But tragically, God's provision ends up being abused or distorted in some way and thus causes a downfall. As a result, the future deliverance becomes bound up with the hope of a future seed, who will be born from the "woman/building" (the ark, the tabernacle, temple, house of David, etc.).

"[*Tardemah*] sleep blocks all perception in the human realm. In each of these passages there is either danger in the human realm of which the sleeper is unaware, or there is insight in the visionary realm to be gained. Pertaining to the latter possibility, it is of interest that the Septuagint translators chose to use the Greek word *ekstasis* in Genesis 2:21. This word is the same as the one they used in Genesis 15:12, suggesting an understanding related to visions, trances and ecstasy ... From these data it is easy to conclude that ... the description of the man being cut in half and the woman being built from the other half (Gen. 2:21-22) would refer not to something he physically experienced but to something that he saw in a vision. It would therefore not describe a material event but would give him an understanding of an important reality, which he expresses eloquently in Genesis 2:23. Consequently, we would then be able to conclude that the text does not describe the material origin of Eve. The vision would concern her identity as ontologically related to the man. The text would therefore have no claim to make about the material origin of woman."

Walton, John H. (2015). [\*The Lost World of Adam and Eve: Genesis 2-3 and the Human Origins Debate\*](#). IVP Academic: An Imprint of InterVarsity Press.

## Reflection Question

Did any of these word studies unlock a new way to read Genesis 2:18-25 for you? Do you still have any pressing questions about the meaning of any of these words?